Exercise Restart Plan — Michael K C Lim

Age: 55
Status: 2-year break, returning to exercise
Current: Lower back sprain (bone setter treatment, 1-week recovery)
Goals: Running, cycling, weights — get back in shape safely
Created: April 3, 2026

⚠️ Critical Constraints

Factor	Implication
Age 55	Longer recovery, prioritize mobility + strength over intensity
2-year break	Start at 30-40% of previous capacity, not 100%
Lower back sprain	Week 1: rest only. Weeks 2-4: no running, no heavy lifting
Family stress	Keep sessions short (30-45 min), flexible timing
Singapore climate	Early morning or evening training, hydrate well

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📅 Phase 1: Recovery (Week 1 — Apr 3-10, 2026)

Goal: Let back heal fully. No formal exercise.

Day	Activity	Duration	Notes
Daily	Gentle walking	5-10 min, 2-3x/day	Flat ground, slow pace
Daily	Ice (if inflammation)	15 min, 2-3x/day	First 48 hours only
Daily	Gentle stretching	5 min, 2x/day	Knee-to-chest, pelvic tilt, cat-cow
Avoid	Running, cycling, weights, sitting >30 min	—	Let fascia heal

Success markers:

- ✅ Pain-free walking
- ✅ No sharp pain with movement
- ✅ Sleeping through the night

📅 Phase 2: Foundation (Weeks 2-4 — Apr 11-May 3)

Goal: Rebuild mobility, core stability, aerobic base

Week 2 (Apr 11-17)

Day	Activity	Duration	Intensity
Mon	Walking + mobility	20 min	Easy
Tue	Stationary cycling (if available)	15 min	Very light (RPE 3-4/10)
Wed	Walking + core activation	20 min	Easy
Thu	Rest or gentle walk	10 min	—
Fri	Stationary cycling	20 min	Light (RPE 4-5/10)
Sat	Walking + mobility	25 min	Easy
Sun	Rest	—	—

Core exercises (daily, 5 min):

- Dead bug: 3 x 8 each side
- Bird dog: 3 x 8 each side
- Plank (knees): 3 x 20 sec
- Glute bridge: 3 x 10

Weights: None yet — let back fully integrate

Week 3 (Apr 18-24)

Day	Activity	Duration	Intensity
Mon	Walk/jog intervals	20 min (1 min jog, 4 min walk)	RPE 4-5/10
Tue	Cycling (outdoor or stationary)	25 min	Light (RPE 4-5/10)
Wed	Bodyweight strength	20 min	See below
Thu	Walking + mobility	25 min	Easy
Fri	Walk/jog intervals	25 min (2 min jog, 3 min walk)	RPE 5/10
Sat	Cycling	30 min	Light-moderate
Sun	Rest or gentle walk	15 min	—

Bodyweight strength (Wed):

- Squats: 3 x 10
- Push-ups (incline or knees): 3 x 8
- Glute bridge: 3 x 12
- Bird dog: 3 x 10 each side
- Plank (knees): 3 x 30 sec

Week 4 (Apr 25-May 3)

Day	Activity	Duration	Intensity
Mon	Run/walk intervals	25 min (3 min jog, 2 min walk)	RPE 5-6/10
Tue	Cycling	30 min	Moderate (RPE 5-6/10)
Wed	Light weights + core	30 min	See below
Thu	Walking + mobility	30 min	Easy
Fri	Run/walk intervals	30 min (4 min jog, 2 min walk)	RPE 6/10
Sat	Cycling	40 min	Moderate
Sun	Rest	—	—

Light weights (Wed):

- Goblet squat (light dumbbell): 3 x 10
- Dumbbell row: 3 x 10 each arm
- Dumbbell press (seated): 3 x 10
- Farmer's carry: 3 x 30 sec
- Dead bug: 3 x 10 each side

📅 Phase 3: Building (Weeks 5-8 — May 4-31)

Goal: Establish consistent routine, build strength + endurance

Weekly Structure (Weeks 5-8)

Day	Focus	Duration	Notes
Mon	Running (intervals or steady)	30-40 min	Build duration weekly
Tue	Cycling + core	40-45 min	Moderate intensity
Wed	Weights (full body)	45 min	See program below
Thu	Active recovery (walk + mobility)	30 min	Easy
Fri	Running (tempo or intervals)	30-40 min	Slightly harder effort
Sat	Cycling (longer, easy)	60 min	Conversational pace
Sun	Rest	—	Full recovery

Weight Training Program (Wed)

Warm-up (10 min):

- Light cardio (walk or cycle)
- Dynamic stretching (leg swings, arm circles, cat-cow)

Main Session:

Exercise	Sets x Reps	Progression
Goblet squat	3 x 10-12	Add weight weekly
Dumbbell Romanian deadlift	3 x 10	Start light, focus on form
Push-ups (or bench press)	3 x 8-10	Incline → floor → weighted
Dumbbell row	3 x 10 each	Add weight weekly
Overhead press (seated)	3 x 8-10	Start light
Farmer's carry	3 x 40 sec	Add weight weekly
Plank	3 x 45 sec	Add time weekly

Cool-down (5 min):

- Static stretching (hamstrings, hip flexors, chest, back)

📅 Phase 4: Consolidation (Weeks 9-12 — Jun 1-28)

Goal: Solidify habits, increase intensity safely

Weekly Structure (Weeks 9-12)

Day	Focus	Duration	Intensity
Mon	Running (intervals)	35-45 min	RPE 6-7/10
Tue	Cycling (moderate)	45-60 min	RPE 5-6/10
Wed	Weights (strength focus)	50-60 min	RPE 6-7/10
Thu	Active recovery	30 min	RPE 3-4/10
Fri	Running (tempo)	35-45 min	RPE 6-7/10
Sat	Cycling (long)	60-90 min	RPE 4-5/10
Sun	Rest	—	—

Weight Training — Strength Focus

Exercise	Sets x Reps	Notes
Back squat or goblet squat	4 x 6-8	Heavier, controlled
Romanian deadlift	4 x 8	Focus on hip hinge
Bench press or push-ups	4 x 6-8	Add weight progressively
Bent-over row	4 x 8	Strong back = healthy spine
Overhead press	3 x 6-8	Seated for back support

Exercise	Sets x Reps	Notes
Pull-ups or lat pulldown	3 x 8-10	If available
Pallof press	3 x 10 each	Anti-rotation core
Farmer's carry	3 x 60 sec	Heavy but controlled

🎯 12-Week Targets

Metric	Starting Point	Week 12 Target
Running	Walk/jog 20 min	5K continuous (30-35 min)
Cycling	20 min easy	90 min moderate (40-50 km)
Weights	Bodyweight only	Full program with challenging weights
Body composition	—	Noticeable strength + fitness gains
Back health	Recovering from sprain	Pain-free, strong core

⚠️ Red Flags — Stop & Rest If:

- Sharp pain in lower back (not muscle soreness)
- Pain radiates down leg (sciatica)
- Numbness or tingling
- Pain persists >48 hours after exercise
- Sleep disrupted by pain

Rule: "Good pain" = muscle soreness (24-48 hours). "Bad pain" = sharp, shooting, persistent.

🇸🇬 Singapore-Specific Tips

Challenge	Solution
Heat/humidity	Train before 8 AM or after 7 PM
Indoor options	Home cycling (if you have trainer), gym AC
Running routes	Park connectors (PCN), East Coast Park, Botanic Gardens
Gyms	Anytime Fitness (24/7), True Fitness, or home setup
Hydration	500ml before, 500ml during (if >45 min), 500ml after

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📋 Equipment Recommendations

Minimal (Home Setup)

Item	Cost (SGD)	Priority
Resistance bands	$20-40	✅ High
Adjustable dumbbells	$150-300	✅ High
Yoga mat	$30-50	✅ High
Foam roller	$25-40	✅ High

If Budget Allows

Item	Cost (SGD)	Priority
Stationary bike / smart trainer	$400-1500	⏳ Medium
Pull-up bar (doorway)	$40-80	⏳ Medium
Kettlebell (12-16kg)	$60-100	⏳ Medium

🧘 Recovery & Mobility (Daily, 10 min)

Morning (5 min):

- Cat-cow: 10 reps
- World's greatest stretch: 5 each side
- Hip flexor stretch: 30 sec each side
- Thoracic spine rotation: 10 each side

Evening (5 min):

- Hamstring stretch: 30 sec each leg
- Piriformis stretch: 30 sec each side
- Child's pose: 1 min
- Deep breathing: 2 min

📊 Tracking Progress

Weekly check-in (Sunday evening):

Question	Scale	Notes
Back pain (0-10)	0 = none, 10 = worst	Should trend down
Energy level (1-10)	1 = exhausted, 10 = vibrant	Should trend up

Question	Scale	Notes
Sleep quality (1-10)	1 = poor, 10 = excellent	Key recovery marker
Workouts completed	/7 planned	Aim for 80%+
Mood (1-10)	1 = low, 10 = great	Exercise should help

Log in: `memory/exercise-log.md` (I'll create this for you)

🪷 Mindset for Success

What Works at 55 (vs. 35):

Age 35 Approach	Age 55 Approach
Push through pain	Listen to your body
Max intensity	Consistent moderate effort
Skip warm-up	10 min warm-up non-negotiable
Train tired	Rest when needed
Compare to others	Compare to last week's you

Your Advantage:

- Wisdom to pace yourself
- Patience for long-term gains
- Clarity on what matters (health, family, purpose)

📞 When to Get Professional Support

Situation	Who to See
Back pain returns	Bone setter (you have one) or physio
Want form check	Personal trainer (1-2 sessions)
Plateau after 8 weeks	Coach for program adjustment
Knee/shoulder pain	Physiotherapist
Motivation struggles	Accountability partner or coach

🙏 Final Notes

Michael, this is your comeback.

Not a race. Not a punishment. A return to vitality.

Key principles:

1. **Week 1:** Rest fully — let the bone setter's work integrate
2. **Weeks 2-4:** Build the foundation — mobility, core, easy cardio
3. **Weeks 5-8:** Establish rhythm — consistent routine
4. **Weeks 9-12:** Strengthen — add intensity safely

If you miss a week: Just restart where you left off. No guilt. No "making up."

If pain returns: Step back one phase. Heal. Then progress again.

You've got this. One week, one session, one breath at a time.

Created with care for Michael's health, family, and coaching journey.

Next review: May 3, 2026 (end of Phase 2)